

Looking Back IN ANGER

Pinki Virani wields her pen like a lance, skewering evil-doers in this abrasive yet energetic book



RAVI S SAHANI

| By Manjula Padmanabhan |

As social commentary, this is a fast-paced, angry book enlivened with sparky humour and broad-spectrum morality. As a novel, however, it totally tanks.

Not that it matters very much—the tanking, I mean. The book's careening energy suggests that its author, the redoubtable Pinki Virani of *Bitter Chocolate* fame, has little interest in mere literature. She wields her writing as a lance, skewering evil-doers with it and riding the high horse of her prose in order to snatch oppressed victims from the funeral pyres of their husbands, their customs, their gods. When one of the characters in her book does this very thing—using a horse to save a would-be sati—you can just see how appealing that image must be to the author.

The bio-note at the end tells us that this is India's "first literary cell-novel and adult audio-mobile book". Was it actually written on a cellphone? Or spoken into the phone and then broadcast live across the electronic universe? Either way, I wouldn't be surprised. It reads like something dashed off in a surge of creative

passion, aimed at the kind of reader who absorbs books intravenously while flying off to attend international conferences on the rights of women and children.

The language is Indo-Angloid, laced with nuggets of Bengali, Gujarati, Tamil and Hindustani. A note at the outset warns us: "This book, as you will discover, contains colloquialisms in several Indian languages. So as not to break narrative flow, non-English text has been encapsulated in translation within the sentence or context." Maybe the average Indian reader is entirely comfortable reading several languages at once, but since I'm not, for me, this was the single least attractive feature of the work. I could see that yes, there was a type of simultaneous translation taking place but it helped only with the raw meanings, not with the irritation. I had no way of knowing whether the exotic spices were actually adding flavour or merely floating alongside the main ingredients, refusing to merge into an integrated curry.

The story is told partly by the hare-lipped protagonist Saraswati and partly as third person narrative. Virani's authorial voice breaks through



DEAF HEAVEN
by PINKI VIRANI
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 283